

Stay Safe Online

A student-friendly guide to passwords, phishing, and data privacy



MIDDLE
SCHOOL

HIGH
SCHOOL

REFERENCE
GUIDE

1. Password Safety

A weak password is like leaving your front door unlocked. A password like '123456' can be cracked by a computer in **under 1 second**. A strong, unique password can take centuries.

- Use **12+ characters**, longer is always stronger.
- Mix uppercase, lowercase, numbers, and symbols.
- **Never reuse** the same password across different accounts.
- Use a password manager (like Bitwarden, free) to store unique passwords.
- Turn on **Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)** everywhere it's offered.

Weak Password	Why It's Weak	Strong Alternative
password123	Common word + simple numbers	Tr@fflc\$1gn@l_24
yourname2010	Personal info, easy to guess	Bl0om#Kayak!92
qwerty	Keyboard pattern, very common	Wh1sper-Gl0w_7x

2. Phishing Awareness

Phishing is when someone pretends to be a trusted source (a bank, a friend, a company) to trick you into giving up personal information. **36% of all data breaches** involve phishing.

Red Flags to Watch For

Urgent or threatening language ('Act now or your account will be closed!') · Mismatched sender domains, like *support@paypa1.com* instead of *paypal.com* · Generic greetings like 'Dear User' instead of your actual name · Requests for passwords or payment info · Suspicious links, hover before clicking to see where it really goes.

3. Data Privacy

Every app and website you use collects some data about you, your location, what you click, how long you stay. Understanding what's collected and why is part of being a responsible digital citizen.

- Check app permissions: does a game really need access to your contacts?
- Read privacy settings on social media, set profiles to private when possible.
- Think before you post: anything online can potentially be seen or saved by others.
- You have a right to ask companies what data they have about you and to request it be deleted.

Quick Self-Check

- My passwords are at least 12 characters with a mix of letters, numbers, and symbols.
- I use a different password for each important account.
- I have 2FA turned on for my email and social media.
- I double-check sender addresses before clicking links in emails.
- I know how to check the privacy settings on my favorite apps.

